

welcome. There are two options, live in a life full of contempt, get insulted and abused, or protest in the name of Allah. I decided to do the latter because had it been only for me, it would not have mattered, it's the name of Allah that they wanted to soil and that is not acceptable...

"I experienced an awakening after I committed my life to Allah. Now nothing scares me, life and death are the same. I planted the parcel in Mani Nagar. This association (with other accomplices) was the most passionate phase for our life, nothing mattered, there was no ego, we can do anything for Allah. We're all equals in the jihad for Allah, but I was associated longer with the *Allah ke bande* (men of God). He was happy with the way things were happening. A handful of *Allah ke bande* were able to paralyse the economic life of such a big country by targeting metros and nothing much could be done about it. We gave back what we were getting from them.

"Atif used to say no one can touch us, we are for Allah. He is dead, we are here (in the prison), no regrets, it's Allah's test of our fortitude. They (police) have seized a bucket in which we kept the

barood (explosives), plastic tape, timer watches and the bags we used...As I told you there is nothing to hide. We are not thieves."

Saqib Nisar, 23

A Jamia Millia Islamia graduate, now pursuing a management course from the Sikkim Manipal University, accused of being a part of the Karol Bagh reconnaissance team.

"It is difficult to be a Muslim in India. I did it for Allah. It's a jihad for Allah. It was Atif who told me that only a few privileged get to wage jihad for Allah. We loved to hear him talk. He would talk for hours about jihad. He was passionate about it and infused the same in me. *Maidan Pukarte Hain* (a book about the struggle of the Mujahideen against Soviet occupation in Afghanistan) says that Allah helps a true jihadi, always. And I believe it. Allah does miracles to help a true jihadi, that's true... For many years Atif did not tell his real intent, the real task for me. He wanted to make sure I could do it. I always knew I had the fire for jihad. Atif was killing people. He told me, sometimes you have to adopt evil to prevent a bigger one. It's not for me or for you; it's for Allah."



the year 2008, our *annus horribilis*, is the face of the terrorist, a pronoun of fear we are still struggling to comprehend. Jaipur, Ahmedabad, Delhi, Mumbai and many more with lesser impact and death toll have become topographical sketches in the narrative of a nation terrorised. Each of these places is a story in itself. The retelling only makes us aware of our own weakness as a nation, the twisted morality of our politics, and, most frighteningly, our refusal to violate the freedom of the terrorist.

Still, to remember is to calm the dead. In Jaipur (May, 80 killed), the picture postcard city, Ahmedabad (July, 53 killed), a power house economic development with glaring communal fault lines, and Delhi (September, 26 killed), the national capital, the killers chose the method of serial blasts—jihad as cowardice. In Mumbai on October 30, it was a frontal attack on the financial citadel, prolonged and spectacular, and the killers were ready to be killed for the cause. A textbook case of *fidayeen* (suicide) attack: make hell, gain *houris* in paradise. Excluding Kashmir and the North-east, over 400 Indians and foreigners were killed in the struggle for a unipolar caliphate. For, only the naïve and the politically dishonest would argue that the terrorist has no religion. Say it once more and you would be further insulting his god and his mission. The ideology of jihad is as old as Islam, and it has become so elastic a term that it can suit the bloodlust of the revolutionary as well as the pacifism of the preacher. The cult of permanent struggle runs through the liberation text of almost every guru of "pristine" Islam, whether it is Syed Qutb, considered to be the patron saint of modern jihad, or Hasan al-Banna, who established the Muslim Brotherhood, or Maulana Maududi, the founder of Jamaat-i-Islami, or Muhammad ibn Abd al-